

Core words that *do academic work*.

A few flexible words let him reason about any subject — not just label it.

The idea: the specific noun (photosynthesis, denominator) names the topic, but core words let him have an idea about it. Model these while you teach, pick one for a word-of-the-week, and he can comment, compare, question, and object across every subject.

COMPARING & QUANTIFYING

the language of math & sorting

more less same different big little most all some

Math: "more than," "less," "the same" • **Science:** "different," "which is bigger" • **Reading:** "same as the other one"

DESCRIBING & ANALYZING

describe anything without the exact noun

big little hot cold fast slow hard long good bad

Describe, don't label-hunt: "it's big and fast" beats hunting for "cheetah." Works for a character, a color, a reaction, a shape.

CAUSE, CHANGE & SEQUENCE

the verbs of process & narrative

go stop make turn put change happen do again

Science: "it changed," "make it go" • **Reading:** "what happened next" • **Math:** "do it again," "put it here"

QUESTIONING & THINKING

the most important academic move

what where who why how think know not like

Ask and answer: "what happened," "why," "I think," "I don't know," "not that one." **Not** is a big one — negation is real academic thinking: "not the same," "that's not right."

POSITION & RELATIONSHIP

quiet heavy lifting

in on up down out off here there

Math: "put it in," place value • **Science:** "where it goes" • **Directions:** "on top," "over there"

One word, *every subject*.

Pick one core word, saturate the week with it. Here's how five of them travel.

TOP TEN TO START WITH

more

different

same

stop

go

make

change

not

what

put

"more"

Math	"one more," "more than five"
Reading	"read more," "what happens"
Science	"more heat," "add more"
Snack	"I want more"

"different"

Science	"it looks different now"
Reading	"a different character"
Math	"a different shape"
Art	"a different color"

"change"

Science	"it changed," states of matter"
Reading	"the character changed"
Math	"change the number"
Weather	"the weather changed"

"stop"

Science	"make it stop," "it stopped"
Reading	"stop here," "the end"
Behavior	"stop," "I need a break"
Music	"stop and go"

"not"

Math	"not equal," "not the same"
Reading	"that's not right"
Science	"not alive," sorting
Choice	"not that one"

How to run a week: put the word on a sticky note where you can see it, model it out loud on his device a few times an hour, in every subject. By Friday it's his, and it works everywhere.

Remember: "photosynthesis" and "denominator" are fringe — he can label them, but labeling isn't thinking. The core words above are what let him **reason** about the topic. Fringe names it; core lets him have an idea about it.